

Aiming High: The Inspiring Journey of Kartik Toward His Dream

Kartik , a 13-year-old boy from Rajgram, Korapara in the Murarai-1 block of Birbhum district, stands as a beacon of hope, resilience, and determination. Belonging to the Scheduled Tribe community, Kartik's life story is a powerful reminder that with the right support and perseverance, children from even the most marginalized backgrounds can aspire to and achieve great things. Currently studying at Rajgram Mahamaya High School, Kartik undertakes a challenging daily commute of nearly half an hour by bicycle from his village to school—a journey that not only tests his physical endurance but also his commitment to education.

Kartik's family background is marked by economic hardship and social vulnerability. Living with his parents and elder brother, the family struggles to make ends meet. His father, a daily wage laborer, works far away in Kolkata and lives apart from the family for most of the year to earn a livelihood. His elder brother helps by working in a local garage, contributing whatever he can to support the household. Meanwhile, Kartik's mother manages the home, taking care of their daily needs despite limited resources. The financial instability within the household posed serious challenges to Kartik's schooling. Education, which should have been a priority, was at risk of being sidelined due to these constraints .

In the beginning, Kartik's school attendance was irregular. The long distance to school, originally covered on foot, was a significant barrier. His academic performance began to suffer, and the risk of dropping out loomed large. Without consistent encouragement or support, Kartik's dreams appeared fragile—much like many children in similar socio-economic situations.

The turning point in Kartik's life came when the CRY project team, during their regular community outreach, identified his plight. Concerned by his frequent absences, the team conducted a thorough assessment, speaking with his teachers, peers, and family members. They uncovered multiple challenges: financial hardship, lack of parental involvement due

to the father's absence, and the influence of peers and family members. They uncovered multiple challenges: financial hardship, lack of parental involvement due to the father's absence, and the influence of peers who were disengaged from school. The team's holistic approach enabled them to design targeted interventions to address these barriers.

One of the most impactful steps taken was the provision of a bicycle to Kartik. This seemingly small aid drastically cut down his travel time and eliminated the daily physical strain of walking long distances. The bicycle became more than just a mode of transport—it was a symbol of support and belief in his potential. With this newfound mobility, Kartik's attendance improved dramatically, rekindling his interest and engagement in school.

Behind this success was the dedicated effort of the project team members—Chandranath Mukherjee, Abhi Konai, Utsab Gupta, Somnath Karmakar, Prasenjit Mandal, and Abhijit Datta. They did not stop at material support; they made repeated visits to Kartik's home, counseling his parents on the importance of education and consistent school attendance. Through patient dialogue and continuous motivation, they helped the family recognize the long-term benefits of schooling. The involvement of local community stakeholders further reinforced these efforts, creating a supportive environment around Kartik and his family.

Gradually, Kartik's parents began to change their outlook. They understood that education was not merely a formality but a crucial tool to improve Kartik's future prospects. Their active support manifested in ensuring the bicycle was maintained and encouraging Kartik to attend school regularly. This shift in attitude marked a critical milestone in Kartik's educational journey.

Today, Kartik is a proud student of Class VI, attending school consistently and excelling academically. His recent exam result of 314 marks is a testament to his hard work and renewed focus. Bengali is his favorite subject, reflecting his connection to his culture and language, while he also enjoys creative activities like drawing, engaging in sports, and practicing yoga for physical and mental well-being. Beyond academics, Kartik harbors an ambitious dream—to join the army and

serve his nation. This aspiration is fueled by the confidence and motivation he has gained through the unwavering support he received.

Kartik's story is not just about overcoming obstacles; it is a shining example of how timely intervention, community support, and individual determination can transform the trajectory of a child's life. From a boy at risk of dropping out to a motivated learner with dreams, Kartik's journey inspires hope and reinforces the profound impact education can have in breaking the cycle of poverty and marginalization.